

Key Takeaways—Employment First Case Studies: Highlights of State Implementation of Employment First Efforts

In the most recent [Access to Integrated Employment study](#), the Institute for Community Inclusion framed the national data on states' Employment First efforts in relation to the High-Performing States in Integrated Employment model. This model sets out the key elements of effective employment policy used to support job seekers with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD) in the general workforce.

Extensive case study data was collected for a sub-sample of 7 states: Connecticut, Delaware, Kansas, Missouri, Minnesota, Tennessee, and Washington. These states were selected because they represent a wide range of implementation strategies, not necessarily because they were experiencing high rates of integrated employment.

Tennessee colleagues and SELN representatives from Delaware, Minnesota, and Missouri presented on the approaches they have used to improve outreach and stakeholder engagement.

Lessons Learned

- » Create and invest in provider capacity-building strategies, including enhanced rates related to better retention, training, and outcomes.
- » Recognize how IDD system decisions affect other state agency partners. Commit time for a wide range of partners to collaborate on and support Employment First efforts.
- » Use data to drive decisions, and confirm that actions taken result in improved employment outcomes for people with IDD.
- » Identify data collection strategies at state and local/regional levels to track approaches that support employment. Identify providers who excel and practices that are creating change, and use them to modify other practices that are less effective. Target specific challenges and provide focused interventions based on the data collected.
- » Pay attention to marketing and core messaging. Ask families, individuals, and providers what is important, and use that feedback to continually shape decisions.
- » Be transparent to build trust. Provide access to updates and resources, and create tools that appeal to a variety of stakeholders. Communicate regularly to dispel myths and misconceptions around IDD and employment.

SELN Hub members can navigate to the [Monthly Network Meeting groups page](#) for additional materials and discussion.

[Meeting Recording](#)



**State Employment
Leadership Network**

The SELN is a place for states to connect, collaborate, and create cross-community support regarding pressing employment-related issues at state and federal levels for individuals with developmental disabilities.

The SELN was launched in 2006 as a joint program of the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.

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